



iQOO Hyderabad City Battle — Shortlisting Research

Objective

Collect first-hand observations from participants in the completed Bengaluru, Pune, and Chennai City Battles to improve our chances of being shortlisted for the Hyderabad offline round.



These are participant observations, not confirmed organizer rules. We should trust patterns repeated across independent replies and validate important requirements against the official submission form.

? Questions used in outreach

◆ Initial questions

1. What problem statement and track did your team submit?
2. What do you think made your application stand out?
3. From what you observed, were certain tracks or types of problems more likely to get shortlisted?



On-ground insight question

After attending the offline event and seeing all the selected teams, what “unwritten pattern” did you notice in the projects that got shortlisted? What should we clearly demonstrate in our application to qualify?



Follow-up questions

- What was common among shortlisted teams: the problem, target users, uniqueness, or on-device AI?
- How important was meaningful phone/on-device usage for shortlisting?
- Did an optional prototype or demo video noticeably improve selection chances?
- Were some tracks more competitive than others?
- Was there anything organizers or mentors emphasized onsite that was not obvious from the website?
- After seeing the selected projects, what would you change in your original application?

Participant replies

Nabil Shaikh

- **Track/project:** Productivity — “Clawdroid,” described as a native Android agentic application.
- Believes uniqueness, problem-solving automation, and scalable on-device functionality helped the project stand out.
- Suggested considering vision AI because many projects appeared to be related to vision.

Tejesh Kunapareddy

- Did not think certain problem categories received priority; observed diverse problem statements and tracks.
- Open Innovation appeared to have the highest representation.
- A repeated pattern among shortlisted teams was a clearly defined target user/group and a specific, well-understood problem.
- Teams explained the problem and target user clearly, built a good application, and used the provided phone heavily.
- Security was a visible theme onsite:

- A professional-track winner addressed modern toddler security.
- A student-track winner addressed identity security during live calls/camera use by selectively blurring another person's face.

Aditya Annamalai

- Participated under Open Innovation and observed that many participants selected that track.
- Reported that a PPT was mandatory for idea submission.
- Said a video and partial prototype were optional, but submitted both to strengthen the application.
- Believes Open Innovation may offer flexibility, but this is personal opinion—not evidence of a higher acceptance rate.
- Emphasized meaningful use of phone capabilities such as the camera, microphone, processor, RAM, and other hardware features.
- Reported that a Chennai winner built a project using the iQOO phone camera.

Archit Khandelwal

- Recommended combining unique features with something people can use daily on mobile.
- The solution should make everyday tasks easier.
- The team must demonstrate why the application is important on a phone and explain the user area/use case it covers.

Subham Sai Samal

- Was selected for the offline event but could not attend because a laptop was unavailable.
- Submitted an EdTech problem statement.
- Offered to answer additional questions about the application and selection process.

Other contacts (replies pending)

Garv Bansal, Prem M, Muhammad Danish, and Melvin Kannan replied and invited questions. Their detailed shortlisting insights are still pending.

Common patterns across the replies

1. **A specific user and sharply defined problem matter more than choosing a supposedly “high-acceptance” track.**
2. **The phone must be essential to the solution**, not merely a screen for a web application.
3. **Meaningful device capability usage stands out:** camera, microphone, local processing, on-device AI, or other hardware-assisted workflows.
4. **Unique but practical beats unique but vague.** Daily usefulness and a clear outcome were repeatedly emphasized.
5. **Open Innovation appears popular**, but popularity does not prove that it has a higher acceptance rate; it may also be more competitive.
6. **Security and vision AI appeared repeatedly onsite**, particularly in Chennai, but we should not copy those themes unless our problem genuinely fits them.
7. **A mandatory PPT plus optional proof**—prototype, video, or other evidence—may make an application more credible, but we still need more replies to confirm how much optional material affects shortlisting.

Working shortlisting hypothesis

Specific target user + painful, well-understood problem + differentiated solution + strong reason to exist on a phone + credible proof that the team can build it.

What we should do now

1 Select the problem before selecting the track

Evaluate each candidate idea against:

- Problem severity and frequency

- Clearly identifiable target user
- Mobile/phone necessity
- On-device AI or hardware advantage
- 30-hour build feasibility
- Demonstration quality
- Privacy, safety, and credibility

Choose FinTech only if it wins on these criteria—not simply because it is trending.

2 Make the FinTech problem narrow

Prefer a specific workflow such as:

- Detecting suspicious payment requests or scam language before payment
- Reconciling UPI receipts, invoices, and merchant records through the phone camera
- Privacy-first local spending categorization
- Accessibility-focused transaction verification
- Explaining loan/EMI/insurance terms in regional languages

Avoid generic ideas such as an “AI finance super-app,” stock predictor, basic expense tracker, or chatbot without a strong mobile differentiator.

3 Design phone-first functionality

The application should clearly answer:

- Why does this need to be on a phone?
- Which phone capability is essential?
- What can run locally or through an open-source model?
- What sensitive data remains on-device?
- What complete user outcome can be demonstrated in under one minute?

4 Prepare convincing submission evidence

- Strong, concise PPT
- One clear problem statement
- Specific target-user persona
- Current workflow and its failure
- Proposed phone-first workflow
- Architecture showing device usage
- Partial working prototype, if possible
- 30–60 second demo video, if permitted
- Realistic sample or synthetic data
- Clear 30-hour execution plan

5 Continue structured outreach 🤝

Ask the same core questions to at least 8–10 participants so answers remain comparable. Record the city, track, selection status, problem, phone usage, supporting submission materials, and advice. Treat a claim as a meaningful pattern when multiple independent participants repeat it.

6 Ask Subham the highest-value selection question ★

Since you were selected, what do you believe was strongest in your submitted EdTech application—the problem statement, uniqueness, phone usage, feasibility, or team profile? Did you submit any optional proof?

✓ Application checklist

- ☐ One-sentence problem statement
- ☐ Clearly named target user
- ☐ Evidence that the problem is frequent and important
- ☐ Explanation of why existing alternatives are insufficient
- ☐ Meaningful phone/device usage

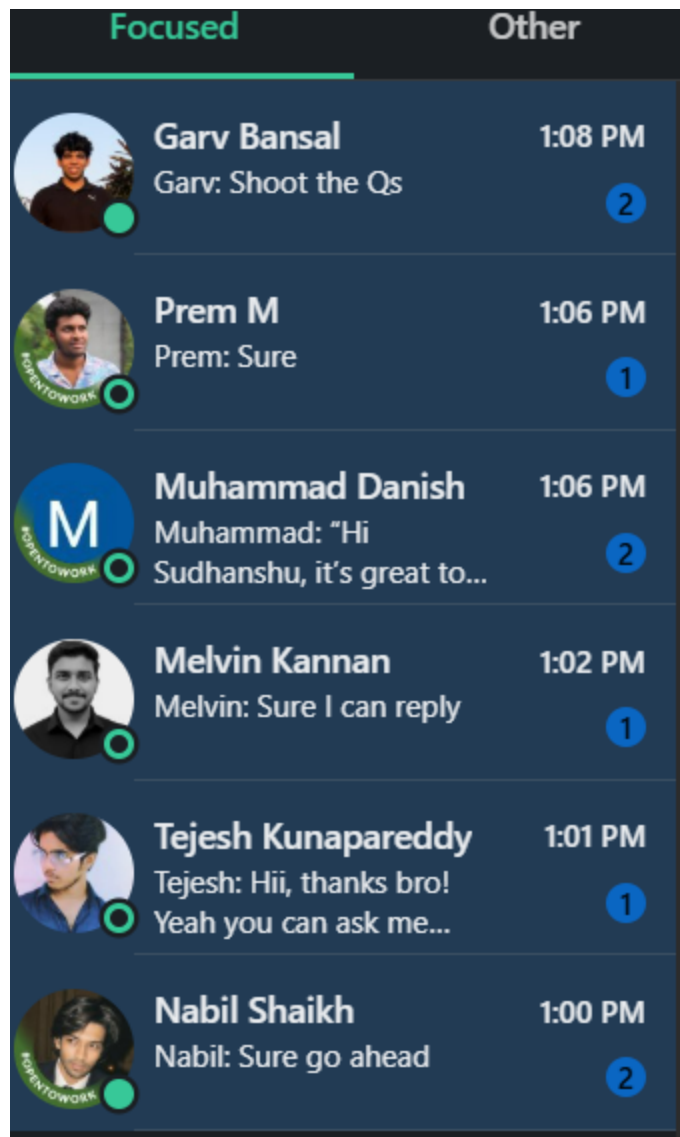
- ☐ Local or open-source AI role
- ☐ Privacy and security considerations
- ☐ Narrow MVP that can be completed in 30 hours
- ☐ Clear differentiation
- ☐ PPT completed
- ☐ Optional prototype/video prepared if accepted
- ☐ Claims kept realistic and demonstrable
- ☐ Submission proofread for clarity



Screenshot evidence

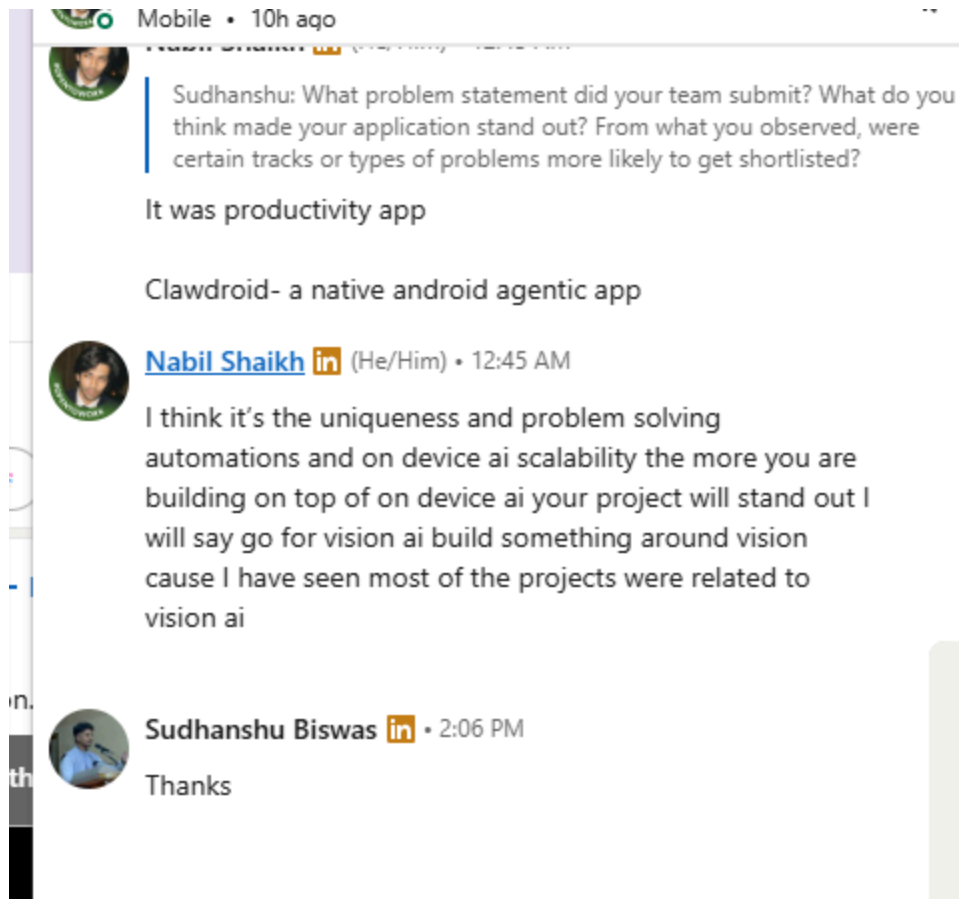


Outreach responses overview



LinkedIn outreach responses

 **Nabil Shaikh reply**



Nabil Shaikh response

 **Tejesh Kunapareddy — initial reply**



Tejesh Kunapareddy (He/Him) • 12:24 AM

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Tejesh Kunapareddy (He/Him) • 12:34 AM

Sudhanshu: What problem statement did your team submit? What do you think made your application stand out? From what you observed, were certain tracks or types of problems more likely to get shortlisted?

I don't think certain types of problems were given more priority. From what I observed onsite, there was a diverse variety of problem statements and tracks represented. I noticed most teams were in the Open Innovation track. One common thing I observed among the shortlisted teams was that they had clearly defined their target users or target group and were addressing a specific, well-understood problem.

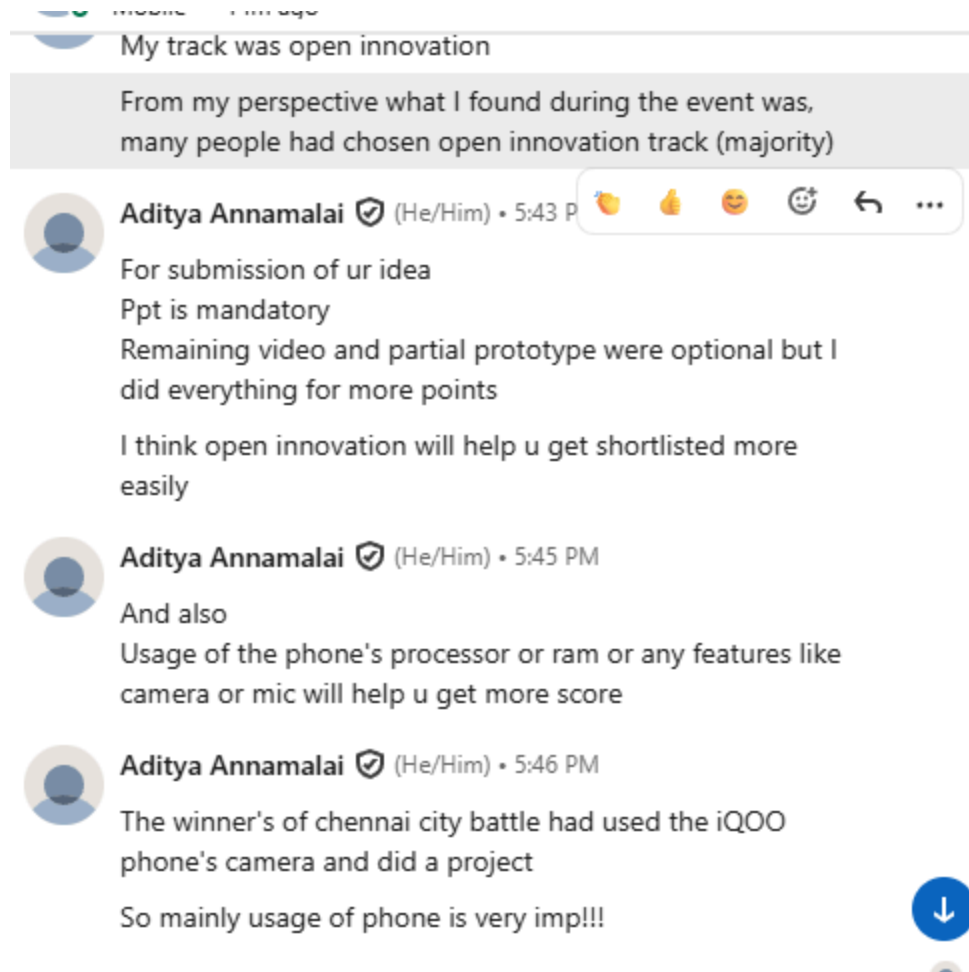
All the best for your submission!



Tejesh Kunapareddy initial response

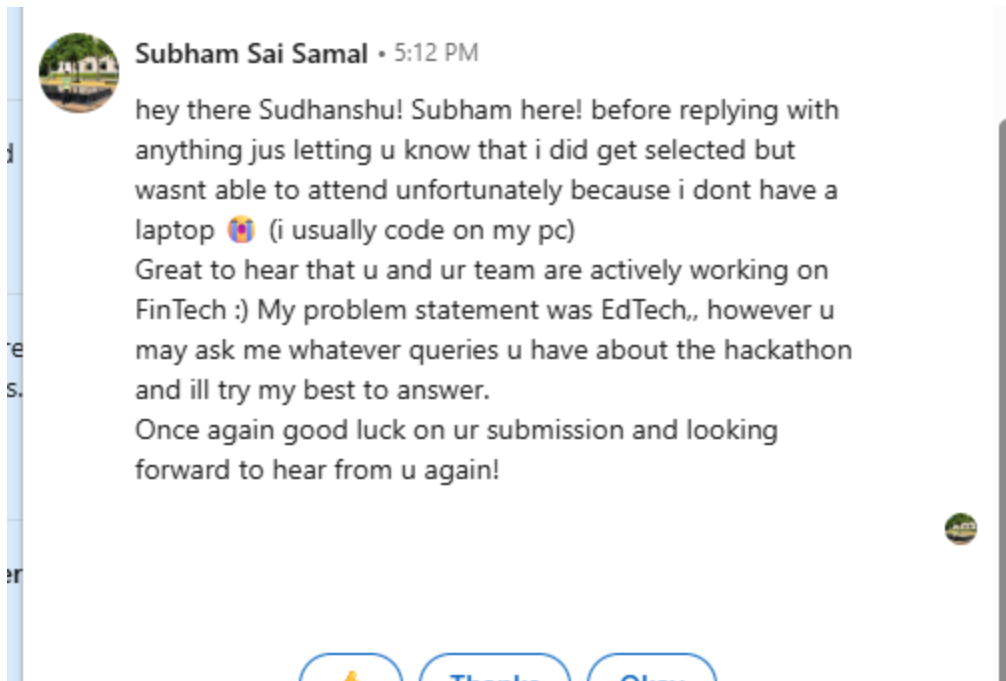


Aditya Annamalai reply



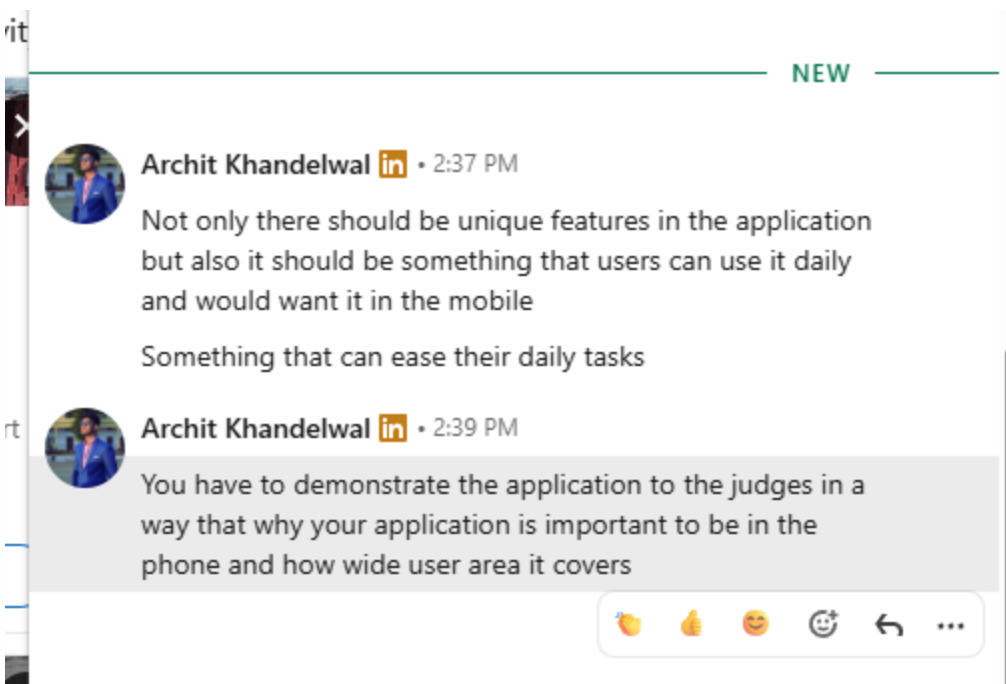
Aditya Annamalai response

Subham Sai Samal reply



Subham Sai Samal response

Archit Khandelwal reply



Arhit Khandelwal response

Tejesh Kunapareddy — on-ground pattern



Tejesh Kunapareddy (He/Him) • 2:37 PM

Sudhanshu: One final question: after attending the offline event and seeing all the selected teams, what "unwritten pattern" did you notice in the projects that got shortlisted? What should we clearly demon ...see more

I'd say, every team got there stated their problem and target user clearly, every team that won made good and heavy use of the phone they gave, and the pattern I observed is security, most of the teams there were solving security somehow, like we were focusing on security during image sharing, the professional track winners were solving modern day toddler security, student track winners were solving identity security in live calls or whenever camera is on by blurring out person's face selectively (Edited)



Tejesh Kunapareddy on-ground response